



Taking tented keyboards even further, some manufacturers offer vertical keyboards. They claim to offer as much as 50 per cent less muscle stress, but the bigger question is what is the learning required?

wrists. This typing posture is in sharp contrast to the way we place our hands on, say, the dinner table. You'll notice that at the dinner table, your hands are placed much further apart than when at the keyboard. This is the specific problem that split keyboards attempt to solve.

Palm rests: Most keyboards today come with palm rests. The simple reason for a palm rest is that it allows your hands to be placed on a firm surface rather than being held in the air by your muscles. This reduces the strain on your muscles and helps relax your arms a lot more.

Tented keyboards: These keyboards look very funny at first, until you understand why they're made that way. Another simple experiment: stand up and leave your arms loosely by your side. Now bend your arms at the elbow and bring your hands up, perpendicular to your body. You'll notice your palms are facing each other (inwards), and not the floor. This is in sharp contrast to the way they are placed when using a normal keyboard, where your palms are resting on the table or palm rest, and facing the floor.

Even in the previous dinner table example, if you notice that when you put your hands up on a table, comfortably, the palms are never facing the table: they face each other. This is the natural position for your hands. So although split keyboards solve the problem of angles, they don't solve the problem of natural palm placement.

This is where tented keyboards try and kill two birds with one stone—the keyboard is split, and also angled like a tent, to keep your hands in as natural a position as possible when typing. Of course you will make a good many typos trying to get used to this style of keyboard, and you'll also slow down your typing speed, but as with everything else, you'll get used to it.

Tented keyboards are an option only for touch typists, for those of us who look and type, the split keyboard is as good as it gets!

Negative-slope keyboards: These are keyboards that have height-raising feet at the front, instead of at the back like most keyboards.

Here's another simple test. Hold your hands out in front of you, palms facing the floor and fingers straight. Now bend the hand downwards from the wrist so that your fingers point at the floor. Now do the same thing in reverse and try and point your fingers at the ceiling. You'll see that it's much easier to bend the hand downwards than upwards. What negative slope keyboards do is try and ensure that your wrists bend upwards as little as possible, and even favour a bend downwards.

It's widely acknowledged that placing a keyboard low is desirable so the arms can straighten as much as possible. Unfortunately, a standard keyboard placed low will cause you to further bend your wrists upwards, thus risking harm. So if you like to place your keyboard as low as possible, a negative-slope keyboard could help ease the tension in your aching wrists.

Ergonomic mice: Though many manufacturers make ergonomic mice, all of which are designed differently and can be really expensive, it's perhaps only gamers and those who use the mouse for extended periods of time without breaks, who might need them. The designs of ergonomic mice are decided in pretty much the same way as that of the aforementioned keyboards.



Here are just a few of the alternate mice available that are ergonomic



In Short

From what you've read thus far, it should be obvious that good ergonomic design means keeping your body in as natural a position as possible, reducing strain on the muscles and tendons. This is why ergonomics is often called the science of fitting a job to the person, rather than fitting a person to the job.

No matter how stressful your work or how busy your schedule, always remember to take a break, shift the body, stretch and relax—all this will help make you more productive, and also eliminate the unwanted costs of balms and sprays! If nothing else, by following these guidelines, you might just start to feel a little younger! ☒

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